



amulets for far more private purposes. They were the custodians of spell books such as *The Book of Overthrowing Apep*. Apep was the serpent who personified the forces of chaos, and whose evil powers were seen as a particular threat.

Although all gods were believed to possess *heka*, that of the lion goddess Sekhmet was especially powerful. Her “Seven Arrows” brought infectious

diseases, and the “slaughterers of Sekhmet,” a group of demonic messengers, could wreak havoc during the five extra days added at the end of the calendar year to harmonize it with the solar year. To guard against them, magicians recited a spell called *The Book of the Last Days of the Year* and wrapped linen around their necks, exchanging amulets in the shape of Sekhmet to ward off Sekhmet’s anger.

▲ God of magic

Heka, the personification of *heka* (magic), is shown with Pharaoh Thutmose III, who ruled in the 15th century BCE, and the ram-headed Nile god Khnum in this relief from the great hall of Khnum’s temple at Esna.